DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

How Does Active Evil Arise From a Withdrawal of Good?

Daat Tevunot §111-114

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §111-114
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 9 March 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

The Rabbi opened at §111 (page 246 in the English) with a recap. Evil cannot be an emanation of its own, because from the good no bad can come, as the Neshamah had wrongly thought. Everything is created through emanation, and evil arises when the emanation is not full. With 100% the result is pure good; with 0% there is nothing; with 99% almost perfect good; with 1% almost all bad.

A participant recalled that the Rabbi had once spoken of Moshe being shown God's "back". The Rabbi agreed this fits: being shown from the back means not being shown the full emanation. The more concealment, the more the knob is turned, the more bad there is.

§111-112: two ways of creating

The Neshamah summarises (§111): this world, made of good and bad, was created in two ways. One is emanation, the other is lack of full emanation. The Sekhel confirms (§112): anything good comes from God's emanation, anything bad from the lack of full emanation. If we see both in the world, God has done two things: He emanated, and He withheld.

§113: the Neshamah's remaining difficulty

Then the Neshamah raises one more problem (§113), the one a participant had raised the week before. I accept that good is created from emanation. But how can anything be created from lack and withdrawal? From absence you cannot seemingly create things. So I am forced back to what I first thought: either God created bad, or bad cannot exist.

The Rabbi sharpened the question. Withdrawal explains imperfection. A child born blind, deaf, or without a limb: there was a hashpaah for the creation of that child, and part of it was closed off. An illness where a person simply has no energy and cannot get out of bed: that too is a lack. But some evil is active. Cancer is not merely missing energy; something in the body is actively attacking you. Night is the absence of day, and that explains darkness. But how can there be, within the darkness, things that positively attack you?

The class debated this at length. One participant suggested that once the dial falls low enough, things flip into active destruction; the Rabbi asked where that active force comes from. Another said that when the lack of emanation is there, the sitra ahra comes and attacks. The Rabbi told him he was on to something that would be part of the answer.

He also reminded the class that the yeser hara is not the mystery here. We learned in Section 4 that the body is created from concealment, and the yeser hara is simply our animal self, while the soul comes from the full illumination. What we did not yet understand is the mechanism behind it: how something actively bad can exist.

Shevirat hakelim, the breaking of the vessels

Before reading the answer, the Rabbi mentioned the Kabbalistic idea of shevirat hakelim, the breaking of the vessels. In the Lurianic teaching of the Arizal, there was too much light for the vessels, they broke, and the light scattered and must be gathered up. There is another way of understanding it: things broke and did not work out as they were meant to, because of the lack of hashpaah. From that lack, bad is allowed to breed. This, he said, is close to what the Ramhal explains next.

§114: two stages of creation

The Sekhel answers (§114). When Hashem created the world, He first created everything in general, and then the details. The Rabbi linked this to a Tuesday night class on Torah and evolution: on the first day everything was created in its general form, and then the details came out.

Stage one, the general creation: Hashem gave an emanation to create the good, and part of its perfection was withdrawn. That allowed things not to be perfect. This is general imperfection.

Stage two, the details: everything, including the details, still needs an emanation, because nothing exists without one. But in the detailed stage, Hashem's hashpaah comes after an earlier withdrawal. It is energy given to something that is already imperfect. That is what gives the imperfect thing the ability to produce actual evil. The Rabbi compared it to "giving someone who's not very good a cannonball to go and do more bad." This, he said, is where the Kabbalistic concept of the sitra ahra, the other side, comes from.

He emphasised that the withdrawal was never total, or everything would cease to exist. That is why withdrawal alone cannot create existence. It was reduced only partly, like a person who becomes ill but does not die. And the foundation stays the same: God only does the good; the bad comes from the lack of the good.

Open questions

A participant asked whether the withdrawal then takes on an independent identity. The Rabbi said this needs more discussion: "There's a reason why he's written two pages on this." Another asked whether some people are born from the sitra ahra from the start. The Rabbi rejected this: the body is born from concealment, and how differently people are born depends on how much concealment they have. He left that for the following week.

He asked everyone to read the two pages of English commentary over the weekend, so the class could see how evil not only exists but actively creates bad in the world.

Summary

- §111-112: good comes from God's emanation; bad comes from the lack of full emanation.
- §113: withdrawal explains imperfection, but how can it produce things that are actively harmful, like cancer?
- The Rabbi mentioned shevirat hakelim: things broke because of the lack of hashpaah, allowing bad to breed.
- §114: creation came in two stages, general and detailed; in the detailed stage, energy flows into what is already imperfect, and that gives evil its active power.
- The withdrawal is never total, and God still only does good; the sitra ahra comes from this second stage.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/wNYjU6BT42k · More shiurim: rabbikada.com